Inferno

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by riverblaster

Summary

Love isn't erased just because trust is broken. Nathalie and Gabriel are still at odds - but they still have that connection, much as it hurts. They fall into old habits, and it helps about as much as you can guess.

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(inspired by a Tumblr post by asukiess)

Notes

Happy birthday Asukiess! Would you believe me if I said I actually started this before your birthday? Now if only I was able to post it before then, too... Ah well. Hope you enjoy! (Feel free to shoot me if you don't lol)

The screen of her tablet was off. For just a moment, it functioned as a mirror; sallow skin, dark eye bags, and her eyes just a little more lifeless by the day. She pinched the skin of her cheek, thin and weak, and watched a blood vessel pop, red blossoming underneath the skin like rouge on the cheek of a girl first learning makeup. The pain was bright, but it wasn't enough to overtake her disappointment.

Hawkmoth failed (*again*), though she couldn't truthfully say anymore that she was surprised. Every day brought a new desperation and madness that tore through the house in a suit of white, and every night found a despair and depression that settled over the estate dark as ash. Though she'd finally come to terms with the wrong they'd done, and done her best to get him to see reason, the only thing she'd accomplished thus far was not completely severing the connection they had to one another.

He'd be coming into her room any moment. The live news broadcast had ended a few minutes ago and the Ladyblog had finished its updates, after all; he was, yet again, defeated, and life across Paris had been returned to normal upon the backs of a swarm of ladybugs. Frankly, it'd been the predictable outcome based on the pathetic akuma he'd created out of someone's rage at a traffic jam (not that knowing that made the loss hurt any less). It was a coin flip between whether he would be displaying rage or sorrow by the time he reached her door; twice this past week he'd come to her with rage, as he preferred to keep sorrow close to his chest and only allow it out when he was truly at an impasse - and yet, with time running out, perhaps that impasse was finally upon him. In either case, what could she say to comfort him that she hadn't already said hundreds or even *thousands* of times? *It'll be okay, Gabriel. You'll get their Miraculouses next time. Emilie will be with us soon.* It was a temporary fix for an addiction, and was growing to be an obvious lie as well.

She heard hurried footsteps coming up the hall towards her room. Lowering her tablet, setting it upon her nightstand, she patiently watched the door. The footsteps hesitated outside, and she could imagine the way Gabriel hesitated as he reached for the handle before withdrawing slightly. He took a half step back, then shifted his weight forward slightly as he debated it. It would be *sorrow*, she guessed, as his rage never thought twice. Finally, there was a timid knock at her door, quickly overshadowed by the door immediately opening and him entering her room before she could allow entry.

Gabriel stepped into the room weakly, warily, his eyes downcast and his face horribly aged in his misery. He looked, it ached her to notice, almost like *Adrien* did these days, misery bone-deep and guilt baked-in. If only he would take those emotions and do something right with them! He closed the door slowly behind himself, then leaned against it as though to keep intruders out - or, she mused, to prepare himself for her cruelty.

"Nathalie," he said quietly, his voice choked up. He lifted his head to meet her gaze, his blue-gray eyes dark and watery like overcast skies. "I failed. *Again*. I-I..."

Her heart broke for him, the same ache she'd felt a million times over. Sympathy, understanding... *exhaustion*, so truly enmeshed with her character that she thought even if she were cured one day it might still remain. Even though they were on different paths now, she was still weak, still cared more than she should've.

"I know," she admitted as he walked into the room. He collapsed half onto the mattress beside her, curled over himself to hide his face in his hands. There was still the slightest cast of pink to his cheeks and ears from his defeat, the ghost of rage-shame-sadness clinging onto him. "I saw-"

"*Again*!" he repeated loudly, sharply, the kind of bite in his voice like that in the bark of a hurt dog at a worried bystander. His face fell again, indignation to misery, and his voice broke as he murmured softly, "How many more chances can there be? How many more until I...? Until *we*...? Until ***she***...."

Nathalie's heart broke further; her moniker was as much of a joke as she was, and it had to be a mercy that her Father did not know just how far she'd fallen from the day she'd received it. She reached out with shaking hand - this from sickness, rather than some girlish anxiety or mistaken sympathy - to pet his hair, running her lithe fingers through the soft white strands despite knowing better. He relaxed into her touch just as she knew he would, his features softening ever so slightly. His eyes closed, she wondered who he imagined was touching him just then.

"You can't keep this up," she coached, the same speech in the same tone. How much weight could the words have after they've been said so many times? He wouldn't see reason and she couldn't give him hope, not any more. "You can *still make this right*."

Her hand drifted down to caress his cheek, a phantom touch and a fool's move. Her hand was so pale it looked almost gray against his warm-toned skin, like she was a step away from death's door - laughable, considering he was right there with her. Her thumb brushed his cheekbone and stole some of its warmth, the heat of his skin seeping into her flesh like it was molten. He reached up and arrested her hand, his own resting atop hers, holding her closer to him.

"How many more times must I suffer defeat at their hands?" he breathed, his voice thick and far away as he ignored her. He felt comforted by his own ignorance, and there was nothing she could do to rip it away from him, try as she might before to do so. He held her like a wave caressed a body, heavy and uforgiving. "How many more times must I lose to them?"

"You have to stop trying," Nathalie begged, desperate for Emilie's message to reach him. "Every failure brings you closer to the point of no return." *And every defeat brought him closer to despair - was he not already past the point of no return anyway?* They'd once shared wells of hope much too deep to be reasonable, but where hers skewed now towards acceptance, his skewed towards obsession.

He sighed, warm breath ghosting over her wrist. "I'm running out of time," he admitted. "What if I don't...?"

"You'd be fulfilling her wishes," she replied more forcefully. "Gabriel, you can give up now, can still do the right thing. Think about your son; think about Adrien." His eyes flickered under closed lids, though it still wasn't enough. Nathalie steeled herself and prepared her trump card. "You have to do it for *Emilie*." What a bitter taste, using Emilie's name for such a horrible reason, and yet she thought Emilie would agree strongly with her doing so.

He stiffened, jolting slightly. His eyes finally opened, staring off at something she couldn't see. "*Emilie*," he breathed, pulse jumping in his throat.

"You can spend the last of your time fixing your mistakes," Nathalie stressed. Unease was blossoming in her chest because she knew, could *feel*, that she'd worded it wrong and it hadn't worked. Despair whispered within her that there was no right way to word it, no way to reach him and drag him back from the brink he'd long ago passed. She flexed her fingers and let her nails scrape gently against his skin, attempting to ground him. In the past, she would've rather manhandled him into common sense, though she increasingly rarely had the energy or the strength to do so anymore. "You can still make it right. You can still make sure *Adrien* is protected."

He sat up, still clutching her hand to his cheek. There was light in his eyes again, color blooming under his skin. Like a tired engine given new charge, he was fired up once more, and she, rapidly losing the urge to fight a losing battle, was that battery.

"For Emilie," he breathed again, a broken record that should've been thrown out long ago. He looked past her tired eyes and saw *through* her, to the ghost of a soul that once fought alongside him and did everything they never should've done.

Nathalie leaned forward, glaring with intention. *"Not Emilie,"* she growled. "You have to let her be. You have to focus on who is *still here*." Although, who was that to Gabriel? His son and, with some stretch of the imagination, Nathalie - both souls that paled in his eyes to the one resting below the house.

"I... I am," he agreed, smiling softly. For the whisper of a moment, he relaxed slightly, eyes drifting closed again. She wanted to ask who he was focusing on - *Emilie*, or *Ladybug*? Because it wasn't her and it wasn't Adrien, that much she knew.

"Gabriel," Nathalie whispered, her own voice hoarse and the last remnants of heart within her chest weakly beating. "Can't you see reason?"

He jumped, then looked at her almost defensively. "For Emilie," he intoned, sure of himself, "I do." He squeezed her hand slightly, and for just a moment, she thought she heard crackling. He smiled at her then, as though their conversation had been anything besides one-sided. "Can't you feel it, Nathalie?" he asked softly, his voice low. "Can't you feel how *close* we are to achieving our dream?"

We, he said, *Our*, like they were still on the same side, still fighting the same fight. She despised that word and despised everything it had come to mean while living in that house, under that roof. She hated the woman she'd become under its influence, and the man she'd enabled him to be because of it. Sometimes Nathalie wished she'd been the one Cataclysmed and he the one who used the broken Miraculous; at least then perhaps days, weeks, *months* of lying in a bad and losing the ability to move freely might have finally afforded him the chance to think through things, to grieve the way he already should have.

And yet...

Even with hatred, with disgust, with self-loathing and guilt and regret, hearing him use that word still made her melt. The promise of mutual success, of shared goals and plans and two hearts beating as one, weakened her like no other. Even knowing better now, there was still a part inside of her that she hadn't yet killed, one which she suspected would only die when *she* did. It was the part that was weak to Gabriel's hopes and fears, strengths and weaknesses, joys and sorrows, and it was what reacted inside of her when he fixed her with *the look*, that one that mirrored from within him the very parts of him that she had fallen in love with all those years ago. She saw that expression and her traitorous heart jumped in response, her pulse kicking up as if it had the energy to spare.

It was *weakness,* pathetic and simple*,* that had her slipshod walls and morals crumble and which made her lean into him slightly, almost imperceptible to anybody who wasn't as close to them as they were to each other. His eyes grew half-lidded as, unspoken agreement met, he moved her hand, dragging her touch lightly over his cheek. At the pulse of her inner wrist he paused, eyes closed as he breathed in the perfume she'd sprayed there earlier in the day (perfume being increasingly easier than showering nowadays, loathe as she was to admit it). Nauseous with the wrongness of it all and sick with the excitement of what was to come, she studied his face, the long lashes and the pores hidden by luxurious makeup and strong nose and sharp cheekbones and pink lips and angular chin, every part something she'd long ago lovingly memorized. His eyes opened again, the blue of a stormy sky over the ocean, and he pressed his lips to her inner wrist, letting the vein throb against them. She let herself get lost in his gaze, that same low, simmering heat and charm that she recognized from endless expeditions over mountains and under sheets.

He stood up gracefully and offered her his hand the same as had so many times before, as though he were asking for a dance (if he said the words, she would've chided him and reminded him she never danced, even before all of this happened). Wrongfully, she took it and borrowed enough of his strength to stumble to her feet, her hand tightening around his as she readjusted, her orthotic's automatic balance adjustment kicking into action now that she was upright. As it did so, he drifted closer, his hand slipping from hers to her waist, before wrapping around her back. He touched a point she could not feel, metal and not skin, and yet was as aware of as her own flesh.

"May I?" he breathed lowly, lips ghosting the shell of her ear. The scent of him embraced her just like his hands, cologne and his natural musk and then a whispering crackle of something darker and altogether *wrong*, barely noticeable under every protection he had in place.

The heat of his breath made her shiver and sharply inhale, her eyes fluttering for just a moment and goosebumps appearing across her flesh. She swallowed, mouth suddenly dry, and nodded. Then, discontent with such a pathetic display, she made some noise of consent in the back of her throat, though she couldn't quite form the words, couldn't let go of that last bastion of long-lost self respect.

He knew her prosthetic skeleton just as he knew her, had been right there with Tsurugi-san overseeing the development as it was created and personalized to Nathalie's preferences (and, of course, his own style choices). He knew just what to press - the first button, to lock the prosthesis in place (and her along with it), the second to open the restraints that kept her inside, and the third to make it balance itself without her in it so it didn't fall. The restraints

opened with a small hum and a slight buzz, the momentary constraint reminiscent of standing upon the edge of a cliff. He offered his hand again and softly smiled, teeth just barely peeking out from behind his lips and eyes warm and welcoming, like the man he was before any of this happened. Feeling more vulnerable now than she soon would naked, she took it.

The first step was always the worst. Like emerging from a pool of water after a long submersion, her body had to get used to its own weight again. She kicked her heel off and then stepped down, the scant difference already making her feel small. She fell forward as soon as her foot attempted to take her weight, but where she would usually grab the side table or push herself back onto the bed, he steadied her and held her close instead. In a way, it felt just like old times - she giving herself to him body and soul, he taking her lead and charging forward when she could've lingered a moment longer instead. It was enough nostalgia to make someone (not *her*, of course) cry.

"I've got you," he whispered softly. She closed her eyes and hummed weakly, hands wrinkling his suit with how tightly she was grasping onto him. If her tight grip and long nails hurt him, he didn't show it.

The next step she took was easier, his hands on her hips steadying her and his body close enough that her head nearly rested against his collarbone. As soon as she was free of her heel and no longer confined by her prosthesis, she turned to the bed (with some assistance) and dropped heavily upon it, sighing. He dragged the metal skeleton to the side, quietly straining against it; only a prototype, the metal wasn't as light as it could've been if it had been an already-existing, mass-produced design. He placed it further out of reach than she preferred, but, then again, she wasn't surprised; when he came into her room most days, he overlooked the faux-spine to instead look straight at her. He rarely thought about the special care she now needed to take, the million tiny things that she needed to do these days just so he could take her for granted; it would've thrilled her once upon a time to be so overlooked. She scooted backwards on the bed using her hands, a clumsy and awkward drag, until she rest against the pillows. Prosthesis out of harm's way (or, at least, out of *his* way), he turned to her once again and moved closer.

He put one knee on the bed, nimble fingers resting against the comforter as he shifted forward. One foot still resting on carpet, he swayed like a willow in the wind under the influence of rot, the subtle creaking of the springs in her mattress virtually indistinguishable from the crackle of his flesh. He needn't worry about falling, of course; she surged forward to steady him, to hold him up at the expense of her own comfort, so common to them it felt comforting. He took that opportunity to straddle her legs for a moment as he regained his balance, grasping her headboard as he breathed through a jolt of pain. After a moment, he slowly exhaled through his teeth and shifted his touch. He held both of her cheeks now, like she were something precious to him, and it would've felt like a cruel joke if she could summon any amount of mental fortitude whatsoever. She wondered - could he feel her atrophying on the inside? No, she suspected, if only because she could not feel his rot, his decay.

He leaned down in a way almost prince-like, burying his face in her neck until his hot breath scorched against her feverish skin. So used to the sensation of him ensconcing her, she instead focused on removing his clothes as fast as she could. Tie instead of cravat, zipper

instead of buttons, tight pants instead of regular suit pants, everything just slightly to the left of what she remembered from the last time this happened. This craving, this *ache*, just slightly to the left of what last she remembered.

As his lips roved over her neck, teeth and tongue teasing the too-sensitive skin, his hands moved lower, slipping deftly into her blazer with the ease of being the very hands that created it. The pressure, either from him leaning on her to kick his shoes off or simply from using her for balance, shifted his weight down upon her spine (that part which still had feeling, at least), forcing her to gasp in pain while stars crowded her eyes. It felt like how one might expect an ice pick being jammed vertically into the vertebrae might feel, electricity arcing through every nerve as though trying to fry her alive. Almost immediately he moved his hands and shifted his weight, relieving her; she, dazed, let herself sit idle for just a moment, breathing through the remaining agony while he undid the buttons of her blazer. He whispered apologies into her neck as he slid the garment off of her shoulders and she, following his lead, lifted her arms out of it like a well-behaved child. He folded her blazer with a gentleness that she barely noticed, staring at the zipper of his vest as her vision cleared.

It was an off-putting sensation, watching his hands slip under her shirt and skirt across her hips and stomach, flesh that once was so sensitive but which now only registered his touch as something slightly abnormal, only barely notable in the same way a shadow on a moonless night might appear slightly darker than its surroundings. Of course she knew the physical barriers of sensation she possessed, but when only feeling her own hands upon herself, she could almost ignore it the same way she always ignored her own body and feelings; seeing his hands, the feeling still seared into her memory but no longer into her nerves, touch her and produce nothing more than the barest of tickles, could've killed her with its loss. He pulled her shirt up, up, *up,* over her head, and she felt a stomach-sinking misery about it all. Her bra she undid herself, as though to retain some sort of agency; she struggled with the front clasps (the preferable style lest the prosthesis interfere with back clasps), still reeling from both the shock of pain and the lack of feeling, and Gabriel was patient as he pretended not to notice, instead biting bruises into her pale skin. Her breasts sagged as she discarded the bra, nipples hardening in the cool air, and she breathed a heavy sigh of relief and joy at completing such a simple task.

Upper half bare, she trembled underneath him, feeling half-frozen just as she always did these days. His warmth reached out to her like a radiant sunbeam and she wrapped her arms around him, forgoing undressing him for a moment so she could instead leech off of his heat like a snake in the sun. He smiled against her collarbone as his hand atop her breast injected heat into her body, right over her heart, aided by the thick white gloves he still wore. She shivered against it and him both, teeth clacking quietly as she pressed even more firmly into him until he had to grit his teeth and pull back slightly - only this once, though, as she was a quick learner.

Clumsily, he stumbled over her legs. It would've been easy to discount that as merely being caught up in the moment, if only she didn't see the phantom spectre of ash seeping through the knees of his pants. Overactive imagination or not, she could recognize his body and all of its quirks and changes even if she were blinded; even now, with so much different between him, she knew him better than she knew even her own gore and viscera. Once properly

positioned, he pulled back slightly, and she, dog on a leash, followed after him, only belatedly remembering herself and the pathetic restraint she was supposed to have. His hands teased at her waistband, a sensation not-unlike the pins-and-needles feeling of frozen muscle gently thawing, before he leaned back and touched her ankle. She felt the gentle tap of his fingers as the knock of a knuckle upon a doorway, a beg for purchase, and their eyes met for just a moment.

Hands braced against her headboard, she pushed herself forward, her legs twitching and weakly shifting to allow her to properly reach him. She grabbed him again by that *damn* vest with that *damn* zipper (scratching against her now-soft hands, no longer owning the callouses of the physical work she once did) and pulled him down until he stumbled over her body once more. One hand caught at her shoulder, winding her, and the other caught in her sheets, making him wince and gasp, eyes blowing wide at the weight against such a weakened part of himself. Awkwardly, they both caught their breath, chests heaving. Even through pain, she felt some sense of victory that she was able to budge him so.

Hands shaking and breath still coming fast, she took the opportunity to slide his jacket free, and where in the past she might've attempt to fold it properly and set it aside before the act, the well of contempt within her urged her instead to cast it away, off the side of the bed and onto the floor. It looked wrong down there, blinding pure white against faded antique carpeting not vacuumed in some time, like a void had opened in her floor and was slowly swallowing whole everything she knew. Rather than annoyance, he looked at her again and *smiled*, an expression so filled with fondness and that *other feeling* she no longer wanted to give name to, and it broke her heart all over again. He looked down his body and she followed him as he unzipped his vest and gently set it aside, not on the floor with his jacket but rather upon the farthest side of the bed, and she again reached forward, this time to undo his tie. Her fingers brushed against his neck and it was *fascinating* to not be able to note his pulse, to feel the skin cooler on that side where the rot was creeping and be unable to steal his warmth from one half of his body. Meekly, she sat back and held his tie in her hands, staring down at it emptily as he undid the buttons of his shirt. This, too, he set aside with his vest.

Still wearing his pants as well as his long sleeve undershirt, they were on more even ground now, though not quite enough. Nathalie reached for the hem of his shirt, avoiding his eyes, and he caught her wrist before she could grab it. Bringing her hand to his lips, he kissed her inner palm, then shook his head slightly; he didn't want to remove the shirt. Slow and stumbling as they were, they were learning things about each other just like it was the first time all over again. It felt like a rejection in a way - didn't they know enough already? Did it really have to change so much?

"Comfort?" she wondered quietly, breaking the hot silence between them.

"I don't want to dirty you," he replied softly, earnestly. He smiled at her with a gentleness that she'd only ever seen reserved for one other.

She laughed quietly, shocked. "Who do you think I am?" she interrogated, though her voice broke just slightly. Her hands curled into fists, nails biting into the same palm he'd just kissed. He disgusted her in ways that only he could manage, and yet never enough to make her flee - though she couldn't now even if she wanted to.

She wasn't a clean woman, he wasn't a pure man; their histories made that so. It was like a stop sign was inserted into the conversation, halting everything in its tracks for just a moment. His eyes widened and he swayed over her again for just a moment, clearly trudging through a sea of memories to return to the present. When finally he returned to her, there was something sad in his eyes; *that*, at least, felt familiar.

Hesitantly (more than she preferred), he finally removed his under shirt, and as his body flexed, his grimace visible momentarily as soot-black skin flakes peeled off of him and drifted down onto her bedspread and his pants. She could've made a joke about polka dots being the next hot clothing print, but that, too, was a joke better suited to another's voice. He set the shirt aside as she gently ran the flat of her fingernail over the border between healthy and rotten skin, tracing herself into him in the hopes it might ground him. The flesh between the two halves was still intact, but slightly darkened and pulled taut, like a scar; it was rough and dry, even with the medicated ointment (prescription-grade from a doctor paid enough not to care about why he wanted it) he slathered liberally onto it and the desiccated skin above it throughout the day, and she had the feeling that if she were to dig her nail in just a little deeper, it might peel away with ease. He shivered under her ministrations, hand twitching on the bedspread as though both wanting to stop her and not at the same time. Did it tickle? Or did it burn? She used to know his shiver of pain from his shiver of pleasure, and yet somewhere along the way, she traded the ability to read him for some weak moral spine, more cartilage than bone and bought with the exchange of her strength and the rest of her life.

He leaned away and touched her ankle again, still wearing his gloves. He had no hesitation this time as he popped one hidden snap, then the next, slowly moving up her leg. *Pop, pop, pop*... visually, the pants were almost indistinguishable from normal ones, and yet up the outer seam of both legs were snap closures, a modification Gabriel made specifically just for her in her weakened state. It was easier for her this way, something she could sit down and put on by herself without needing to be dressed by someone else. Who could she have asked to help? *Gabriel*, too busy with his final battles? *Placide*, too busy doing the lion's share of work around the estate now that she was increasingly unable to? *Adrien*, who had experience thanks to caring for Emilie to varying degrees throughout his young life, but who Nathalie could never allow herself to beg for assistance? No, the ability to dress herself was a mercy Nathalie gripped onto as tightly as she could, and one of the things she most thanked Gabriel for as of late.

He popped the final snaps open and pulled both front and back parts of her pants free. Even these he set aside with tenderness, letting them rest next to his own clothing as though they belonged together. He ran his hand soothingly up her unshaven legs, and she barely felt it.

"This is new," he muttered, tracing a scar on her inner thigh. He pulled her legs open wider to get a better view, hot breath a barely-there tickle as he touched the raised, reddened skin.

Her eyes tightened as she recalled the incident. It was from an accident some months back, when she was first getting used to the changes in her body post-Peacock usage. She'd slipped in the shower when her legs randomly gave out, and managed to slice herself on her razor. Blood dripped from the rip like a faucet, the pain strangely muted back then in a way she hadn't realized was precursor for what was to come. Like an old horror movie, it flooded the white floor of the shower, and grew pink with the water that mixed with it. Where the stream

from the showerhead hit it, it splattered, and red spotted the wall and alternately the curtain as she struggled out of the shower, nearly slipping in her haste as she dripped yet more blood against the floor, then the toilet as she sat upon it, and drenched the towel she used to staunch it. In kind words, it was an annoyance, and it was pure luck she hadn't needed stitches to close it. Back then, she could still feel almost all of the pain, so the first few days were filled with hidden grimaces and routine checks to ensure she hadn't bled through the bandage and her pantsleg. As soon as the bleeding was staunched, she'd ordered herself a shower chair, and it felt almost comical these days how luxurious it felt to be able to sit and shower at the same time - she even found herself thinking sometimes how nice it would've been even when she was at full health, like on those days she'd been exhausted, or sick, if only she'd thought to get a chair back then. Not that those thoughts did her any good *now*, of course.

"That's not what's important right now," she replied slightly too sharply, dragging herself away from the memory. She could've begged him not to remind her of what she once was, but she didn't see the point in it; they both knew, and they were both pale imitations of their healthy selves.

He looked up at her like a dog kicked, then looked away again, his expression sorry. "I suppose you're right," he muttered, subdued.

He trailed his hands upwards again, this time to her hips, and found the adaptive underwear she wore, this with hook-and-eye closures for ease of removal. He undid these quickly, hands just as skilled at taking off clothing as it was at putting it together, and pulled them free of her body immediately. As he set them to the side, more flakes drifted off of his body and down onto her marble-white legs. At a glance, they could've been freckles dotting her skin.

He was upon her again, pulling her close, and she was both there with him and also somewhere far, far away. Her room was a cave high upon a mountaintop, her lamp was a campfire, the pills upon her side table were provisions, and his body upon hers was her blanket and her bed mate both. His left hand was more rough than the right, the rot creeping down his arm and drying that hand in preparation for it to crumble away; it was a delicious mix of sensations that drew soft gasps from Nathalie as one soft hand groped her chest while the other rough hand roved over her side. Her nails scratched against his back as she pulled him closer, and they came away blackened.

He looked at her again and she buried her face in his neck, softly biting at the blackened skin, tasting ash upon her tongue; this way she was spared from his eyes looking down at her with that softness that begged to keep her captive all over again, that look that she once swore she would do anything for. Delirium whispered she might eat him whole if she continued, and instability suggested she try it, though discipline reigned in the end. She grasped for the zipper of his pants and was met with the curious inability to find it, another oddity added to their old-new relationship. She palmed across his pelvis, ghosting over his groin as she searched, until he finally chuckled and sat back.

"Leggings," he explained to her as he dipped his thumbs into his waistband. It seemed obvious in retrospect.

"...I imagine the fashion writers are shocked," she replied with a small, dry smile.

"Audrey has dubbed them the latest and greatest menswear trend of the last century," he added wryly, rolling his eyes. "I wonder where that enthusiasm will go once I no longer wear them."

You'll never stop wearing them, Nathalie thought, watching him slowly slide them down. *You'll be buried in them.*

It took some effort for him to maneuver out of his pants while seated on the unsteady surface on the mattress, but finally he managed, leaving soot handprints across her sheets. For sake of her ease, he removed his underwear as well. Something in her raged at the thought he didn't think her capable, and something else was relieved at him doing so, given she was already at the point where she needed to carefully weigh every action she took so that she wouldn't run out of energy too soon.

She only saw his groin for a moment before he settled back over her. His pelvis was blackened, slightly smoother and softer than his chest and stomach - this, she supposed, because it was more freshly desiccated - and his pubic hair, pure white and a length that suggested it was trimmed in the past but not so recently, seemed almost shockingly bright in comparison. From the base of his hardened cock up about a third of the length the skin was black, and for another third it was scar-tissue dark and suggesting it would soon rot as well, while the final third, the tip, was pale, a reddish-pink not from sickness but from arousal. Disgust and heartbreak roared within her at opposing heads, and she was relieved when he nipped from her collarbone down to her breast, mercifully unintentionally hiding himself from her view.

She grabbed his hips and pulled him to her, urging him to grind against her (as she could not quite control her lower half enough to do so without support); she enjoyed, in turn, the pleased purr that traveled from his throat through every awakened nerve of her body. His arms wrapped around her body, embracing her as he followed her lead, and she panted against his shoulder as though she were the one doing all the work. His shoulder against her lips, she tasted ash like her tongue was cleaning the hearth; she bit into his shoulder just to see what she could find, and at his throaty, lustful cry, she found solid flesh over sturdy bone - a promise, at least, that his body wasn't fully taken over yet. He had time, just like she, and rather than using it to pursue madness or logic (impossible to do both), they chose this instead.

With a quiet groan, he sat up, perching over her. Her pelvis was cool from a patch of wetness she could only suspect was from him, but she didn't have the chance to look before he descended upon her body again with lips and tongue and teeth. She jolted, gasping underneath him, and was shocked by the intensity the pleasure of just his mouth brought her. The doctor (one of them of an endless revolving team; Gabriel had almost fallen into old habits when first she had fallen weak and had searched high and low for a doctor who could offer a cure; thankfully, he had been relieved of *that* ailment, at least, relatively quickly) had warned her as much would happen over time, that the parts of her body she *could* feel might pick up the slack for those parts she felt lessened or lack of sensation in. But still, she hadn't expected *this*....

Her eyes rolled shut, panting quietly as she abortedly realized she'd grabbed his head, her hand tight in his white hair. She tried to reason with her own body - *get it together, your chest was never that sensitive!* - but reason was too quick to abandon her when rare pleasures were presented to her. She moaned loudly as her head fell back against the pillow, entire body twitching like she was already upon the verge of orgasm, and she wasn't even sure how to stop it with as out-of-tune with her body as she was. He hummed against her, drinking in her reaction with an expression that was almost hungry, and embarrassment crawled up her back to make her sweat. She finally released his head, blinking hard and fast while he smiled around her nipple.

"You've never enjoyed that so much," he muttered, seemingly amused as he pulled back enough to speak. He blew cool air over her chest, his smile deepening as she shivered and arched into him, her hands digging in her blankets.

She thought about yelling at him. Instead, she reached forward with both hands and gently grabbed his glasses, pulling them off of his face. She folded the temples back, letting them click against the frame, then set them on the side table. Her own glasses followed suit a moment later, the entire world cast into a fuzzy warmth that took a bit of the edge off of her conscience and allowed herself to give in just a little bit further.

"I've never had a reason to," she responded finally, undoing her hair bun. Black and red hair, almost back to its natural curls since its last straightening was a few days prior, tumbled down her nape. There was a pain deep inside of her ribcage that reminded her that the last person besides herself who ever took her hair down was long gone - no, actually, not *gone*, just in a glass casket underground.

His eyes tightened and he weakly smiled, obviously unsure what to say. His guilt wasn't like hers; she could coast through arousal while guilt simmered inside of her, but he had always been the type who could only focus on one emotion, and right now he was focusing on her pale body laid bare beneath him (or, at least, he was *trying* to be) .

Mercifully, she reached forward and grabbed his cock, slightly softened but not enough to stop early. The flesh was warm, almost *hot*, more than she recalled being usual, and for a few strokes to get him back on track, she marveled at the feeling of three distinct textures.

He grunted and gripped her wrist tightly, teeth grit. She looked up at him questioningly, one eyebrow raised.

"Too - *heh* - too dry," he admitted weakly, smiling almost embarrassedly at her.

The drag of flesh on flesh needed lubricant, and the drag of ash and decay did as well. How foolish of her not to realize.

She looked to the side table, but didn't have to demand; he knew where it was because it was always there, even in the past when this was something more common between them. He fetched the bottle, untouched now for... *months*? ***Years***? She couldn't remember the last time she'd used it - before Emilie died, maybe? Or, perhaps, late at night, watching Emilie's videos, maybe she had....

He withdrew the bottle from her nightstand and sat up. Before he could pull his gloves off, she captured his hand. For just a moment, they put their hands together palm-to-palm, like some movie about wild men and proper girls; *Hello Nathalie, I'm Gabriel.* Then, Gabriel shifted his hand and looked at her softly, in a way that seemed like it was meant to tell her something. She broke his gaze like the shattering of fine China; *Mr. Agreste, you have no idea of the enormity or complexity of the task you're asking of me.* She pulled his glove from his hand slowly, listening to the scrape of his breathing in case it hurt; *You can call me Gabriel-. No, sir, I cannot.* . Pinkie, ring, middle, index, thumb, each slipped free, and finally she pulled the glove off of his hand, more black flakes drifting down between them. She didn't have the chance to do the same with his other glove because he, impatient or too excited, instead took the tip of his middle finger into his mouth, bit into the fabric, and pulled the glove off of himself by his teeth. Wordlessly, he spat it to the floor with the one Nathalie dropped down there.

Gabriel poured some lube into his palm and she watched goosebumps dot his skin (the healthy parts, at least) as he shivered . He warmed it with both hands, blackened skin absorbing some of the mixture into the cracks while some flakes broke off and became part of the mixture itself. Dully, she thought about what that meant for her own body later, before she remembered she likely wouldn't live long enough to see the consequences anyway. He grabbed his cock and stroked himself over her until even the most ashen parts of it were shiny and slick, the wet squelching of his hand lewd and loud in the confines of the quiet room. It was a hypnotic motion, one she'd oft enjoyed watching over before, not just for the repetition but because of the way his body responded to it; the flush that reddened his cheeks and ears, the way his eyes became half-lidded, the quickening of his breath, all of it beautiful especially here in the soft warm light and fuzziness a lack of eyewear granted.

A feeling nagged at her, one she kicked herself for not realizing sooner; for so much of this, he'd been the one servicing her, but she could never be content with that, even now with her feelings towards him so decidedly lessened. Smoothly, she took over the stroking, and noted the way his body subtly stiffened, before he leaned over her. His hand slid wetly down her thigh, leaving coldness in his wake, as he bent lower, now on all fours above her. Watching him, forgetting her own body and brain, *this* was what she adored, this ability to be of *service*, to *assist* and be made *use* of. How easy it was to transport herself to a smokey office years away when her own feelings were put aside.

He moaned softly, voice low and throaty just like she recalled. Just like her, it had been a long enough time that surely he ached for it, the mercy of release and the momentary peace it would bring, and she wanted to give it to him just as she had given him so much else. Her hand moved faster as she drank in the way his eyes fluttered closed, dark lashes fanning against his cheeks with a whisper of the color his hair once had. His hand was too slick to properly grip her thigh, not that she would've felt it much anyway, but his blunt nails still dug into her flesh while he rested much of his weight against her numbed half. She almost wanted to beg, to ask him to lean more on her, to use her body in every way he needed it, because reverting to that part of herself made stomaching these things she both wanted and despised at the same time so much easier, but she held her tongue; good tools didn't speak. She hid her face in his neck, felt his hot breath against her ear, the sensation shooting a bolt of delicious electricity through her flesh and making her bite her lip in turn.

"Nathalie," Gabriel whimpered softly, breathily.

She swallowed a moan and stroked faster, almost no friction between his flesh and hers.

"*Nathalie*," Gabriel said again, his voice more halting and more wrecked.

She blinked back to herself and slowed her movement somewhat haltingly. Puzzled, she sat back slightly to look at him.

"Gabriel?" she wondered softly, searching his face for any sign of pain.

"Nathalie, *please*," he whispered, looking up at her through his lashes, grimacing not in pain but with desire.

She frowned. What was he asking? What was-

Movement caught her eye and she looked down. Seeing him finger her, and with her not feeling it - or, perhaps, only barely feeling it, that shiver from his breath on her neck indistinguishable from that one caused by the hand between her legs - was disconcerting, admittedly. Still, the sight did at least offer her understanding of just what, exactly, he was begging for. Slick digits entering in and out of her, thumb pointed at clit and moving quickly; if she focused, she thought she could feel them, though no greater, perhaps, than the gentle insistence the need to urinate offered.

"*Nathalie*," he breathed again, though she'd stopped stroking him to instead watch his ministrations. He shifted, dragging blackened knees across her bedspread so that he could press his forehead to hers and arrest her gaze with her own. She blushed, his face in such great definition now that not wearing her glasses was hardly a handicap at all.

She swallowed, then looked coyly to the side. "You can be rougher," she said, her voice tight and low. "I can't feel it anyway." It was an offering, a suggestion; he had deep wells of emotion within himself, so surely they could be emptied this way?

He looked surprised at first, though quickly he accepted this, his eyes crinkling and his smile too close to ignore. He readjusted, still continuing the thrusting of his fingers (no more rough than before), and drifted lower over her body. His lips slid across her neck, his tongue dragging and teeth scratching, while his free hand charted the planes of her upper body as though it had never graced them before. Her noise was one of a pleasurable choke, surprise and desire both shocking into her. Her back arched into his touch, her legs twitching weakly around his hand as she raggedly moaned.

It seemed almost laughable to find the Gabriel she once knew in her room like this. When she knew the Agrestes (*plural*) in the past, they'd always been so generous in their desires, but when she knew Gabriel in more recently memory, he had grown to be rather... *selfish*. This softness of his, this willingness to assist without return, his cock too far out of reach and her body in desire too heightened to reach for it, was... well. Perhaps *welcome* wasn't the right word - though it wasn't wholly the wrong one, either.

Her eyes, almost-closed until now, suddenly widened, and she quickly looked back at him. Still bent over her, he was kissing - no, *sucking* - no, ***biting*** into her breast a bruise that wouldn't disappear for some days. Black, purple, and red, the colors of his upcoming Fall/Winter line, stark against her otherwise pale flesh, like blood upon fresh snow. Emilie had always left marks aplenty, though Gabriel had always erred more conservatively. To see such a sight at such a fraught time... tears filled her eyes and she quickly put her head back and covered her view with her wrist.

Apparently he couldn't just let her be only a tool anymore. He seemingly wanted all of her; didn't he know how dangerous that was?

It felt both a blessing and a curse when he pulled back again, cool air washing over her torso like an arctic blast. Unspilled tears clumped her eyelashes together as she warily peeked at him, and she was almost relieved to see his hand on her hip as he gripped his cock, preparing. Nearly scatterbrained by pleasure, she followed his lead, quickly wedging a pillow underneath her lower body, forcing her hips upwards for him, her heart racing only partially from exertion. Cheeks flushed, she slowly looked up his body, from knees to cock to stomach to breast to throat to face, and he smiled that same *damning* smile that had her relax into the pillows against her best wishes, her hands tightening in the sheets as she did. He lifted her legs and opened them for her, choosing the angle, the width, reforming her until she was perfect for him. She felt, for just a moment, like Galatea, and the sensation was almost too much; everything within her ached, her lungs and heart and ribs and soul, and when she looked wretchedly up at him again, he didn't notice.

It was like a pressure building inside of her, barely more tangible than the air around them. She watched, holding her breath, as he slowly drove himself into her, still thumbing at her clit as though she actually felt much from it; belatedly, she guessed it had to be for her health rather than for her pleasure. Healthy pink skin turned mauve turned black, pushing in for the first time in both too long and yet not long enough. Halfway up his shaft he had to reposition himself, both hands grabbing the bed (not her, not again) to steady himself, and she took over his ministrations if only because she felt he wanted her to, his expression relaxing some when she did so. His arms shook around her, blackened cage keeping her in place, and larger strips of skin flaked off and drifted down to outline her body like a soot angel.

Finally fully inside of her, white flesh swallowing black, he paused and made a sound almost like a relieved laugh. His smile was bright and boyish, borrowed from a Gabriel she knew long ago, and without thinking, she found his hand on the mattress and tangled her own with it. More black ash made its home under her nails and his face twitched with a whisper of pain as she did so, but still he intertwined their fingers as their bodies interlocked. For a moment, they both sat, breathing deeply. This close to him, she could hear the flaky rattle of his lungs; this close to her, she was sure he could hear the wheeze of her own.

It was a bad time for both of them to wrap themselves up so fully in each other, their respective positions making it more difficult and uncomfortable to do than anything. He still needed to prop himself up with one hand, which was now the one he locked her hand down with, her wrist twinging and his hand crumbling. His other hand was at her chest, dragging too-soft nails across her skin and kneading her breast awkwardly, still trying to offer her that same pleasure that she was giving to him. She exhaled and pulled her hand free, throwing her

arms around his neck and pulling him down fully on top of herself, body tense and shaking as her legs twitched and tried to open wider for him.

She was such a damn fool. She knew it, too.

"As fast as you want," she panted breathlessly in his ear.

But he wasn't very good at listening to her anymore, and hadn't been in quite some time. About certain things, yes, but *this* was not one of them. Rather than quick and passionate, fast and messy, pathetic and miserable, he thrust his hips slowly, setting a smooth, dragging pace - *tender*, one might call it. *Intimate*, even. ***Caring***.

He found new ways to break her heart by the second.

He moaned softly, his eyes glazed as he focused on the rhythm he was creating. She fared little better, soft sparks of electricity buzzing across her skin with the motion of his hand on her, concentration on him difficult to come by as her own pleasure was building within her. Compulsion urged her to bring him closer, hand wrapping around his back and nails biting grooves into his flesh as she, in turn, bit into his shoulder, marking herself upon him even harsher than before, a badly trained dog turning on its master. He cried out, his pulse beating weakly under her tongue, as his thrusts sped for just a moment; he tasted like a burn, a cigar, a brand, and drool ran past her lips and down his flesh as she held him there like she was the chain around his throat. She heard his crepitant skin crackle against her neck, the noise of a burning fire and the scent that of a fire long-ended. He embraced every sound she made, thrusting shallowly into her until she finally released him, and at that point, he held her close, his hand petting her hair as his hips met hers. She felt so useless like this, so little to offer beyond her own heightened pleasure, and yet for some reason it only spurred him on.

He pulled out of her arms and left her splayed against her pillows, still thrusting. Both of his hands were fisted in her pillows, clutching them so tightly she heard his skin crackling like logs upon a fire. His eyes were dark, almost empty, as he focused wholly upon the wet clap of their bodies, muscles working in tandem to urge each other on. She preferred it like that, existing more as shadow than soul, and felt herself come more alive in turn, heat crawling up her back and setting her cheeks aflame.

Gabriel's momentum stuttered slightly as he repositioned them both. He moved closer, dragging black streaks into her sheets. Then, as she watched him curiously, one of her hands at her clit just as he apparently wanted, he hefted her leg up, surprising her, and onto his shoulder, opening her wider. She gasped, the sudden movement a shock, and he grinned in return. One hand gripped her hip tightly to keep her up and her heel bouncing against his back as he thrust. In this position, they were both locked in their places somewhat; he couldn't bend over her anymore lest her leg stop him, and she couldn't drag him down again for some reason. It was a pose one might expect to see carved into some statue, barely hidden by marble sheets, and titled something akin to "Taming the Wild Beast" or perhaps "Entryway to Hell" - some commentary on misery and joy and the plight of humanity. In another lifetime, fresh off of expeditions paid for by rich people in want of swelled private collections, she might've enjoyed musing on it; now, though, she found it very hard to think at all.

The blush crawling up Gabriel's healthy skin alerted her to what was coming before he had the chance to. His thrusting quickened, as did his breathing, and his hands, sticky and shiny, dug into her flesh.

"Hah- Em- *Nathalie*!" he hoarsely warned right before it happened. Then he cried out, his thrusts growing sloppy. At the last possible second, he pulled out.

She didn't feel it spilling onto herself. She wasn't sure, given the state of his body, that there actually *was* anything to spill at all, despite visual evidence to the contrary. Gray, watery and specked with black, something that looked altogether unhealthy and like it would've come from a smoker's lung rather than a man's cock, splattered against her pelvis and stomach. It would've been disgusting if she had any sort of normalcy about her at all.

There was a part of her, the part that suffered from some sort of pride or morality or self respect, that wanted to beg him not to help her, but her words were slower than his hands were. His cock still shiny and softening in front of her eyes, he seemed determined to launch a full assault upon her. One hand at her breast mirrored her own hand at the other - *when had she grabbed herself? who even **was** she anymore?* - while his other hand took over at her clit. His mouth, that terrible, wondrous thing, found her neck again, and he nuzzled back her black hair so that he could kiss and lick her skin, her pulse jumping under his lips like it wanted to jump out of her body and into his, two rotten souls meshing into one once and for all.

It would've been a loss to say his name, given how much she had already lost today. Instead, she firmly bit her lip and smothered her moan as she came. It wasn't like her orgasms used to be, focused over her cunt and shivering through her body; instead, she felt it flash across every inch of her body (those parts of it she could feel), like a wave engulfing her. Her eyes squeezed shut, her muscles tensed up, and for a moment she existed in a void made wholly of feeling.

When she came around, she was practically bent in two, crushing Gabriel (and her leg over his shoulder), to her chest. Her nails were creating divots in his back, digging away the creaking dead flesh to reveal the raw, reddened and inflamed muscle underneath, though he made no move to stop her. Breathing heavily, she finally released him, her arms falling weightlessly onto the bed. For a moment, he didn't move, and they shared the same air, his face in her neck and his crackling in her ears. The sweat beading on his brow hinted at the pain he was in, though she barely had the energy to keep her eyes open, much less commentate on it.

He slowly pushed himself up, off of her, and she felt the air return to her lungs in some slight capacity. Sweat dripped down his forehead and his hands shook, but he was still gentle as he moved her leg off of his shoulder, grimacing as the sweat from the back of her knee dragged across his body and stripped a chunk of his dead skin. As he softly laid her leg down, positioning it for her, large spots of soot drifted off of him and down onto her. It was almost laughable to look at it, as spotted as she was; like a dalmatian given spots, she was every bit as speckled now as the dog she'd always been.

Gabriel stared unseeing at her body, and she wondered if he questioned who it was that had done that just now - himself, or another? The gentle hands that caressed Mayura on rooftops

and shamelessly in front of heroes, the soft way he cared for her.... She wondered if he was questioning how much he was still himself, and how much of himself he had given to an alter ego. He returned to himself soon thereafter, closing the curtains upon a scene she knew she wasn't supposed to see.

His eyes traveled up her body, over his semen and the bruises he'd bitten into her, before they landed on her face. He smiled as he softly asked, "How do you feel?"

Her own smile was weak and reflexive. "*Tired*," she admitted with a self-deprecating chuckle. *Just like I always am. Just like I will be for the rest of my life.*

She wanted him to flinch, to apologize, but instead he only chuckled and nodded. He flexed his hand and a crack of red flesh offered a precious ruby droplet.

"You should rest," he said gently. Not *I know how you feel*. Not *I don't blame you*. Not *You've lost your edge, Nathalie*. Only understanding and compassion. She could've been sick, if only the exhaustion would've paused for a moment.

She dozed off as he got up from the bed and slowly, painstakingly redressed himself. Gloves replaced first, compression as comforting as it was uncomfortable. The rest of his clothing followed after in the usual way, though all of it was speckled and all of it would need to be replaced and cleaned before Adrien got home from school.

She woke to the feeling of something warm and wet against her stomach, and her mind offered various perversions until she finally opened her eyes and lifted her head. Gabriel sat on the edge of the bed next to her, slowly wiping his dried spend off of her with a wet rag, one she recognized from her own shower. He was slow, methodical, and precise, first wiping all of it off before folding the rag on itself and then moving to wipe the rest of himself off of her body, spot by spot like he was trying to erase the entire coupling. Speckles, dots, even smears, he gave her a sponge bath until her body - or, at least, the front half of it - was clean again. He even wiped ash away from her mouth, though he couldn't rid her of the taste. Afterwards, while she shivered, frozen, he wiped her dry with another clean rag. When finally done, he moved her legs for her again, then covered her nude body with her comforter.

He stood up with a soft grunt, pain visible in his eyes and every shift of his body. "I'll come gather your sheets and remake your bed soon," he promised kindly, fondly. "Why don't you sleep until then?"

She nodded because it was the easiest thing to do just then.

After he left, every part of her screamed for rest, but her mind screamed back. Tears crowded her eyes and she wrapped her arms around herself, nails digging into her flesh either as penance or as a ground. She mourned the fact she felt so little. She mourned what could've been.

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